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Buying like a BOSS!

As strange as it may sound Agent 001 is also big on festive shopping. But as always he applies his analytical mind to the task.

Agent 001

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It's that time of the year, dear readers, where it'll be exceedingly difficult to distinguish between fact and faff, while mass buying fever will grip everyone in your vicinity — including you. Deals will reign supreme, both online and offline, one better than the other, enticing nay arm twisting you to buy something or the other, even if you don't need it. Brace yourself, the festive shopping season is upon us!

I'm not impervious to these gadget deal temptations, too. To avoid falling prey to bad deals, I follow a buying habit which I've inculcated in me. Think of it as a code, if you will.

Research, research, more research!

If there's one thing you can't do enough of before buying a product is research. Whether it's a Rs. 1000 accessory or an HDTV costing a lakh, I do just about the same amount of research before purchasing anything. For me, researching is a habit which can't be offset by how much a product costs. Ultimately, research is just that - research. And it can go a long way to ensure you aren't taken for a ride or face crushing disappointment in your decision to buy something.

RO-TO-PO

Despite the advent of ecommerce in India, I'm fairly old-school in my buying

habit. While I love the simplicity and convenience buying something online, as much as possible I like to touch and feel the gadgets and gizmos I'm buying. Therefore my mantra here is - Research Online, Test Offline, Purchase Online. Testimonials are no substitute to convincing yourself how a speaker sounds before purchasing it, or the feel of a laptop's keyboard and trackpad. Sure, listen to everyone's advice, but don't be swayed and be your own judge. Like me. This way, you have no else to thank or blame but yourself.

Multiple windows exist

Somehow, I'm convinced that Diwali and Christmas alone aren't the only two annual occasions where you need to save all year and ultimately spend your money. Throughout this year, I've noticed that occasions like Regional and National Holidays are frequent rally points for e-commerce websites to offer attractive deals and discounts. End of season sales that exist offline have also migrated online, leading to a windfall of deals, if you learn to follow their patterns. I've bought quite a few products during these mini-festive shopping bursts.

The thing to do here is to keep an eye on a product you want to purchase, that you're willing to wait for, and track its price across websites. I do this for almost all my online purchases, sometimes from months in advance. I even use several proxies to throw off popular shopping portals' recommendation engines and customization



algorithms just to ensure I'm not being gamed by the system. It seems to have worked so far, and I'm not complaining.

Offline matters

Say what you want about offline buying, it still works for me. I still get great discounts from small and large electronic shops, where I know people, relationships that are decades old and not dictated purely by business interests. Online shopping is too impersonal, in that sense, and still can't match up to this offline buying factor. The whole experience is just something else altogether, something that's fast vanishing. I'm not saying ignore online (if I did, I'd be Agent Doofus), not at all – just don't ignore offline stores and their deals, that's all. I wouldn't be surprised if some of them try to offer better deals than e-commerce sites, at least for a few more years while they continue to be a big force and challenges in covering non-metros still remain for ecommerce sites.

One last thing

Never do an impulse purchase. Never ever. Your biggest enemy in the buying process is you yourself. Be absolutely convinced you need and want something before buying it. 